

*Species of Spaces
and Other Pieces*

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*Edited and translated by
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	SPACE	
OPEN	SPACE	
ENCLOSED	SPACE	
OUTER	SPACE	
	SPACE	SUIT
	SPACE	AGE
LIVING	SPACE	
PROJECTIVE	SPACE	
	SPACE	CAPSULE
LACK OF	SPACE	
	SPACE	BAND
	SPACE	HEATER
DEEP	SPACE	
	SPACE	ODYSSEY
	SPACE	SALESMAN
EUCLIDEAN	SPACE	
	SPACE	CADET
	SPACE	STATION
BLANK	SPACE	
	SPACE	OUT
PARKING	SPACE	
	SPACE	INVADERS
	SPACE	WALK
	SPACE	TIME CONTINUUM
	SPACE	BAR
LOST IN	SPACE	
STARING INTO	SPACE	
WATCH THIS	SPACE	
	SPACE	CURVE
	SPACE	LATTICE
	SPACE	OPERA
CATCHER	SPACE	
	SPACE	SICKNESS
BUNCHER	SPACE	
THREE-DIMENSIONAL	SPACE	
HAIR	SPACE	
	SPACE	RACE
NULL	SPACE	

LEAVE A SPACE
SPACE OF A MOMENT
INTERCOSTAL SPACE
AVAILABLE SPACE
SPACE NEEDLE
POSITION IN SPACE
EDGES OF SPACE
SPACE WRITER
WIDE OPEN SPACES
LACK OF SPACE
SPACE SAVING
ENCLOSED SPACE
SPACE FILLER
WASTED SPACE

Foreword

The subject of this book is not the void exactly, but rather what there is round about or inside it (cf Fig. 1). To start with, then, there isn't very much: nothingness, the impalpable, the virtually immaterial; extension, the external, what is external to us, what we move about in the midst of, our ambient milieu, the space around us.

Space. Not so much those infinite spaces, whose mutism is so prolonged that it ends by triggering off something akin to fear, nor the already almost domesticated interplanetary, intersidereal or intergalactic spaces, but spaces that are much closer to hand, in principle anyway: towns, for example, or the countryside, or the corridors of the Paris Métro, or a public park.

We live in space, in these spaces, these towns, this countryside, these corridors, these parks. That seems obvious to us. Perhaps indeed it should be obvious. But it isn't obvious, not just a matter of course. It's real, obviously, and as a consequence most likely rational. We can touch. We can even allow ourselves to dream. There's nothing, for example, to stop us from imagining things that are neither towns nor countryside (nor suburbs), or Métro corridors that are at the same time public parks. Nor anything to forbid us imagining a Métro in the heart of the countryside [*campagne*] (I've even before now seen an advertisement to that effect, but it was – how shall I put it? – a publicity campaign [*campagne*]).

What's certain, in any case, is that at a time too remote no doubt for any of us to have retained anything like a precise memory of it, there was none of all this: neither corridors, nor parks, nor towns, nor countryside. The problem isn't so much to find out how we have reached this point, but simply to recognize that we have reached it, that we are here. There isn't one space, a beautiful space, a beautiful space round about, a beautiful space all around

us, there's a whole lot of small bits of space, and one of these bits is a Métro corridor, and another of them is a public park. Another – and here we suddenly enter into much more particularized spaces – originally quite modest in size, has attained fairly colossal dimensions and has become Paris, whereas a space near by, not necessarily any less well endowed to begin with, has been content to remain Pontoise. Still another space, much larger and vaguely hexagonal, has been surrounded by a broad dotted line (innumerable events, some of them particularly weighty, had as their sole purpose the tracing out of this dotted line) and it has been decided that everything found *inside* this dotted line should be coloured violet and be called France, while everything found *outside* this dotted line should be in a different colour (although, outside the aforesaid hexagon, they weren't in the least anxious to be of a uniform colour: one bit of space wanted its colour and another bit its, whence the famous problem in topology of the four colours, unresolved to this day) and have a different name (in point of fact and for quite a few years, there was a strong insistence on colouring violet – and thereby calling France – bits of space that didn't belong to the aforesaid hexagon, but were often far distant from it, but, generally speaking, that didn't last half so well).

In short, spaces have multiplied, been broken up and have diversified. There are spaces today of every kind and every size, for every use and every function. To live is to pass from one space to another, while doing your very best not to bump yourself.

The Page

‘I write in order to peruse myself’

Henri Michaux

1

I write . . .

I write: I write . . .

I write: ‘I write . . .’

I write that I write . . .

etc.

I write: I trace words on a page.

Letter by letter, a text forms, affirms itself, is confirmed, is frozen,
is fixed:

a fairly strictly h

o

r

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t

a

l

line is set down on the blank sheet of
paper, blackens the virgin space, gives it a direction, vectorizes it:
from left to right

f

r

o

m

t
o
p

t
o

b
o
t
t
o
m

Before, there was nothing, or almost nothing; afterwards, there isn't much, a few signs, but which are enough for there to be a top and a bottom, a beginning and an end, a right and a left, a recto and a verso.

2

The space of a sheet of paper (regulation international size, as used in Government departments, on sale at all stationers) measures 623.7 sq. cm. You have to write a little over sixteen pages to take up one square metre. Assuming the average format of a book to be 21 by 29.7 cm, you could, if you were to pull apart all the printed books kept in the Bibliothèque Nationale and spread the pages carefully out one beside the other, cover the whole, either of the island of St Helena or of Lake Trasimeno.

You could also work out the number of hectares of forest that have had to be felled in order to produce the paper needed to print the works of Alexandre Dumas (*père*), who, it will be remembered, had a tower built each stone of which had the title of one of his books engraved on it.

3

I write: I inhabit my sheet of paper, I invest it, I travel across it.

I incite *blanks*, *spaces* (jumps in the meaning: discontinuities, transitions, changes of key).

I write
in the
margin

I start a new
paragraph. I refer to a footnote¹

I go to a new sheet of paper.

1. I am very fond of footnotes at the bottom of the page, even if I don't have anything in particular to clarify there.

There are few events which don't leave a written trace at least. At one time or another, almost everything passes through a sheet of paper, the page of a notebook, or of a diary, or some other chance support (a Métro ticket, the margin of a newspaper, a cigarette packet, the back of an envelope etc.) on which, at varying speeds and by a different technique depending on the place, time or mood, one or another of the miscellaneous elements that comprise the everydayness of life comes to be inscribed. Where I'm concerned (but I'm no doubt too choice an example, writing being in fact one of my principal activities), this goes from an address caught in passing, an appointment noted down in haste, or the writing-out of a cheque, an envelope or a package, to the laborious drafting of an official letter, the tedious filling-in of a form (tax return, sickness note, direct debit for gas and electricity bills, subscription form, contract, lease, endorsement, receipt etc.), to a list of urgently needed supplies (coffee, sugar, cat litter, Baudrillard book, 75-watt bulb, batteries, underwear etc.), from the sometimes rather tricky solution to a Robert Scipion crossword to the fair copy of a finally completed text, from notes taken at some lecture or other to the instant scribbling-down of some device that may come in useful (verbal play, verbal ploy, play on letters, or what's commonly known as an 'idea'), from a piece of literary 'work' (writing, yes, sitting down at the table and writing, sitting at the typewriter and writing, writing right through the day, or right through the night, roughing out a plan, putting down capital *I*s and small *a*s, drawing sketches, putting one word next to another, looking in a dictionary, recopying, rereading, crossing-out, throwing away, rewriting, sorting, rediscovering, waiting for it to come, trying to extract something that might resemble a text from something that continues to look like an insubstantial scrawl, getting there, not getting there, smiling (sometimes), etc.) to work full stop (elementary, alimentary): i.e. to ticking, in a journal containing a summary of almost all the others in the field of the life sciences, the titles that may be of interest to the research-

workers whose bibliographical documentation I am supposed to provide, filling in index-cards, assembling references, correcting proofs, etc.

Et cetera.

5

This is how space begins, with words only, signs traced on the blank page. To describe space: to name it, to trace it, like those portolano-makers who saturated the coastlines with the names of harbours, the names of capes, the names of inlets, until in the end the land was only separated from the sea by a continuous ribbon of text. Is the aleph, that place in Borges from which the entire world is visible simultaneously, anything other than an alphabet?

Space as inventory, space as invention. Space begins with that model map in the old editions of the *Petit Larousse Illustré*, which used to represent something like 65 geographical terms in 60 sq. cm., miraculously brought together, deliberately abstract. Here is the desert, with its oasis, its wadi and its salt lake, here are the spring and the stream, the mountain torrent, the canal, the confluence, the river, the estuary, the river-mouth and the delta, here is the sea with its islands, its archipelago, its islets, its reefs, its shoals, its rocks, its offshore bar, and here are the strait, the isthmus and the peninsula, the bight and the narrows, and the gulf and the bay, and the cape and the inlet, and the head, and the promontory, here are the lagoon and the cliff, here are the dunes, here are the beach, and the saltwater lakes, and the marshes, here is the lake, and here are the mountains, the peak, the glacier, the volcano, the spur, the slope, the col, the gorge, here are the plain and the plateau, and the hillside and the hill, here is the town and its anchorage, and its harbour and its lighthouse . . .

Virtual space, a simple pretext for a nomenclature. But you don't even need to close your eyes for the space evoked by these words, a dictionary space only, a paper space, to become alive, to be

populated, to be filled: a long goods train drawn by a steam locomotive passes over a viaduct; barges laden with gravel ply the canals; small sailing boats manoeuvre on the lake; a big liner escorted by tugs enters the anchorage; children play ball on the beach; an Arab wearing a big straw hat trots down the shady paths of the oasis on his donkey . . .

The streets of the town are full of cars. A turbaned housewife is beating a carpet at her window. In small suburban plots, dozens of nurserymen are pruning fruit trees. A detachment of soldiers presents arms as an official wearing a tricolour sash unveils the statue of a general.

There are cows in the pasture, winegrowers in the vineyards, lumberjacks in the forests, climbers roped together in the mountains. A postman on his bicycle pedals laboriously up the hairpin bends of a lane. There are washerwomen beside the river, roadmenders beside the roads, and farmers' wives feeding the hens. Rows of children are coming out in twos into the school yard. A *fin-de-siècle* villa stands all on its own surrounded by tall glass buildings. There are little gingham curtains in the windows, drinkers on the terraces of the cafés, a cat warming itself in the sun, a lady weighed down by parcels hailing a taxi, a sentry mounting guard in front of a public building. There are garbage-collectors filling refuse trucks, decorators putting up scaffolding. There are nannies in the squares, second-hand booksellers along the quays; there's a queue in front of the bakery, one gentleman walking his dog, another reading his newspaper sitting on a bench, another watching workmen demolishing a block of houses. There's a policeman controlling the traffic. There are birds in the trees, sailors on the river, fishermen on the embankment. There's a woman raising the iron shutter of her haberdashery. There are chestnut-vendors, sewer-men, newspaper-sellers. There are people doing their shopping.

Studious readers are reading in the libraries. Teachers are giving their lessons. Students are taking notes. Accountants are lining up

columns of figures. Apprentice pastry cooks are stuffing cream into rows of cream puffs. Pianists are playing their scales. Sitting deep in thought at their tables, writers are forming lines of words.

An idealized scene. Space as reassurance.

The Bed

‘For a long time I went to bed in writing’

Parcel Mroust*

1

We generally utilize the page in the larger of its two dimensions. The same goes for the bed. The bed (or, if you prefer, the page) is a rectangular space, longer than it is wide, in which, or on which, we normally lie longways. ‘Italian’ beds are only to be found in fairy tales (Tom Thumb and his brothers, or the seven daughters of the Ogre, for example) or in altogether abnormal and usually serious circumstances (mass exodus, aftermath of a bombing raid, etc.). Even when we utilize the bed the more usual way round, it’s almost always a sign of a catastrophe if several people have to sleep in it. The bed is an instrument conceived for the nocturnal repose of one or two persons, but no more.

The bed is thus the individual space *par excellence*, the elementary space of the body (the bed-monad), the one which even the man completely crippled by debts has the right to keep: the bailiffs don’t have the power to seize *your* bed. This also means – this is easily verified in practice – that we have only one bed, which is *our* bed. When there are other beds in a house or an apartment, they are said to be guest beds or spare beds. It seems we only sleep well in our own bed.

*A play on the first sentence of Proust’s great novel, *À la recherche du temps perdu*, which reads: ‘For a long time I went to bed early.’

2

'*Lit = île*'*

Michel Leiris

It was lying face-down on my bed that I read *Twenty Years After*, *The Mysterious Island* and *Jerry on the Island*. The bed became a trapper's cabin, or a lifeboat on the raging ocean, or a baobab tree threatened by fire, a tent erected in the desert, or a propitious crevice that my enemies passed within inches of, unavailingly.

I travelled a great deal at the bottom of my bed. For survival, I carried sugar lumps I went and stole from the kitchen and hid under my bolster (they scratched . . .). Fear – terror even – was always present, despite the protection of the blankets and pillow.

Bed: where unformulated dangers threatened, the place of contraries, the space of the solitary body encumbered by its ephemeral harems, the foreclosed space of desire, the improbable place where I had my roots, the space of dreams and of an Oedipal nostalgia:

Happy he who can sleep without fear and without remorse
In the paternal bed, massive, venerable,
Where all his kinsfolk were born and where they died.

José-Maria de Heredia, *Trophées*

3

I like my bed. I've had it for a little over two years. Before that, it belonged to a woman friend of mine who had just moved into an apartment so tiny that her bed, though of perfectly orthodox dimensions, would barely fit in the room intended to receive it,

*Literally 'bed = island', Leiris's point being that the closeness in sound between the two French words has somehow determined the closeness (for him) in their meaning.

so she swapped it for the one I then had, which was slightly narrower.

(One day I shall write – see the next chapter – the history of, among others things, my beds.)

I like my bed. I like to stretch out on my bed and to gaze at the ceiling with a tranquil eye. I would gladly devote the major part of my time to this (the mornings mainly) were I not so often prevented by supposedly more urgent occupations (to list them would be tedious). I like ceilings, I like mouldings and ceiling roses. They often serve me instead of a Muse and the intricate embellishments in the plasterwork put me readily in mind of those other labyrinths, woven from phantasms, ideas and words. But people no longer pay any attention to ceilings. They are made dispiritingly rectilinear or, worse still, done up with so-called exposed beams.

A huge plank has long served me as a bedhead. With the exception of solid foodstuffs (I'm not usually hungry when I stay in bed), everything I couldn't do without was to be found assembled there, in the areas of both the necessary and the pointless: a bottle of mineral water, a glass, a pair of nail-scissors (chipped unfortunately), a collection of crosswords by Robert Scipion (I take the opportunity to address a tiny reproach to him: in the 43rd grid of the said collection, excellent otherwise, he has – implicitly – got *néanmoins* with two *ms*, which, obviously, means that the corresponding word across is wrong [it couldn't decently be written as *assomnoir*] and that the solution to the puzzle has been palpably compromised), a packet of paper handkerchiefs, a hard brush that enabled me to give my (female as it happens) cat's fur a sheen that was the admiration of all, a telephone, thanks to which I was able, not only to give my friends reports on my state of health, but to inform numerous callers that I was not the Michelin Company, a fully transistorized radio playing all day long, should the mood take me, various kinds of music interspersed with whispered news items about traffic jams, a few dozen books (some that I had intended to read and didn't read, others that I re-read

constantly), albums of strip cartoons, piles of newspapers, a complete smoker's kit, various diaries, notebooks, exercise-books and loose sheets of paper, an alarm-clock, naturally, a tube of Alka-Seltzer (empty), another of aspirins (half full or, if you prefer, half empty), yet another of cequinyl (an anti-flu treatment, more or less untouched), a torch, of course, numerous handouts I had neglected to throw away, letters, felt-pens, ballpoints (both these last often dry), pencils, a pencil-sharpener, an eraser (these three last articles intended for the solving of the aforesaid crosswords), a pebble picked up on the beach at Dieppe, a few other small mementoes and a post office calendar.

4

A few other banalities:

We spend more than a third of our lives in a bed.

The bed is one of the rare places where we adopt roughly speaking a horizontal posture. The others are much more specialized: operating table, bench in a sauna, chaise-longue, beach, psychoanalyst's couch . . .

Techniques of sleeping: the idea that lying down is something natural is quite inaccurate (see Marcel Mauss, 'Techniques of the Body', in *Sociologie et Anthropologie*, p. 378; the whole paragraph – too succinct, alas! – would be worth quoting).

And what about hammocks? And paliasses? And bedsteads? And box-beds? And divans deep as the grave? And straw pallets? And railway couchettes? And camp beds? And sleeping-bags resting on air-beds themselves resting on a carpet of earth?